

unlock the country's potential:

► **Ignite the Indian entrepreneurship from the bottom-up.** Entrepreneurship is one of the most egalitarian and non-discriminatory traits. It transcends literacy, age, gender, caste and religion. Just as Mahatma Gandhi mobilised millions of people from all walks of life for the Independence movement, it is possible to organise entrepreneurship at grassroots level. It does not require too much time or too many resources to organise the entrepreneurship movement. It will, however, require a sense of purpose and urgency. Entrepreneurship cannot flourish unless the nation respects it, promotes it and makes good entrepreneurs its heroes, no matter what religion, caste they

Checks and balances:
One of India's biggest assets is its democracy

SAIBAL DAS



belong to. It will also require giving up orthodoxy or respect anchored to history.

► **Encourage public-private partnership.** A second solution is to actively promote and practice public-private partnerships especially in education, health and infrastructure. The investment needs are so massive and urgent that the Government alone cannot satisfy them. It needs active participation by the private sector. The mistrust of the private sector and mismanagement by the public sector needs to give way to a new social contract between the business and the government to aspire to be world-class in education, health and infrastructure. India has already experienced the dramatic impact of cell-phones and wireless networks on its economy and the masses. It is just the beginning.

► **Need for discipline.** Unlocking the potential of India's democracy, diversity and demo-

graphics requires discipline. Without it, there is a possibility of every one becoming dysfunctional. It means making business and political leaders accountable for their actions. It means enforcing laws both by the courts and by force, if necessary, to protect the rights of others. And above all, it also means self-discipline must be imposed from within than without.

► **Reinvent the Indian tradition of welcome.** Historically, most nations have flourished when they have welcomed outsiders, who have often unlocked a nation's potential more than the locals. While this happened to some extent, after India's Independence, it is now time to seize the opportunity and welcome everyone who loves India, wants to invest here, and be an Indian. Our history is replete with contributions made by outsiders to the nation's commerce and culture. This has been the single most important reason for America's prosperity and is becoming a necessity for Western Europe and Japan. There is enough historical evidence to suggest that shutting down the borders is a surefire way of plateauing the nation.

► **Get globally integrated.** The term does not merely mean Indian corporations expanding globally through mergers and acquisitions. It means ordinary citizens becoming aware of the world and having the curiosity to experience it. This also means the desire to learn from the world with humility. Business leaders, religious gurus, politicians and bureaucrats must become conscious of the consequences of their actions on India's image around the world. In today's world of Internet and the omnipresence of the media, it is becoming very difficult to avoid the spotlight. The days of remaining isolated from the world are over.

► **The business of business is more than business.** The traditional view of business as a profit-seeking institution concerned only with the shareholder value must give way—and it is giving way—to a view that the best way to sustain its shareholder value is to attract and retain the hearts and minds of its key resources: customers, employees, suppliers and the community. It also means accepting the corporate social responsibility towards the environment and the society.

Will this work? Only the future knows for sure.

1996

SAW THE FIRST PUBLIC-PRIVATE PARTNERSHIP IN INDIA IN THE FORM OF THE TAMIL NADU URBAN DEVELOPMENT FUND

The author is the Charles H. Kellstadt Professor of Marketing at the Goizueta Business School in Emory University, USA.